

STRATEGY

Strategy games include management games such as *Simcity* and war games such as *Commandos*. God games such as *Populous* and *Black and White* also fall into this category

Age of Empires II



Ensemble Studio's critically acclaimed title

Master the controls

Winning in *AOE II* requires mastery of controls and numbered groupings. Making a huge loop around your troops and sending them at a target is the easiest way to lose a game. Instead, use tactical strategies to gain an advantage and assign formations to your troops.

Use Hotkeys

Assign various units to numbers so that it becomes easy to single out the unit during a heated skirmish. It makes more economy than selecting the whole army and diverting all the units' attentions. It is easier to coordinate that way. When you finally arrive in combat, let your infantry and cavalry attack on their own, but specify targets for your archers and siege weapons.

Tactical warfare

When sending your troops for attacks, make sure they attack specific weaknesses. Skirmishers and mangonels are good deterrents for archers; if you are faced with cavalry, build pikemen. Archers are excellent for bringing down infantry. Monks and pikemen are exceptional for deterring war elephants. In the face of cavalry archers, deploy camels and cavalry.

Formations

It is essential to have a group formation for any major war. When greeting an enemy, switch to flank formation so that your army converges on the enemy from two different sides. If you have swift cavalry, this makes an excellent formation. A scattered formation is a great one for foot archers, for it spreads them out and thus minimises their damage. The box formation is recommended if you have a strong group of melee units.

Command and Conquer



The *Command and Conquer* franchise from Westwood is synonymous with RTS games

Learn the units

Take the time to learn what each unit is capable of. If you like to use the Allies, also play with the Soviets so you can understand completely what each unit does and what its limitations are.

Scout the map

Half the battle is knowing where your enemy is. In the first few minutes of the game, make your first objective to uncover your opponent's base and the surrounding areas. Send your infantry to the corners of the map and a few down the centre. Dogs are great units to use as scouts, and are cheap to produce. They can cover a lot of ground in a short time.

Build your base

Winning in *Command and Conquer*

requires one simple brainwave. If you out-produce your opponent, you will win. When you have control over the majority of the money source, you deny your enemy the only means he has to



The Soviet's airship is a weapon handicapped by slow speed and lack of armour. However, its large payload of bombs can cause serious damage.

build his army. Attack his Ore Miners whenever possible. When you keep this action up, he will be pre-occupied with protecting his Miners. Always expand toward the ore fields as you go. The key is to never stop building.

Base defences

When creating your air defences, it's a good idea to group them. A single Patriot Missile can stop one or two V3 Launchers, but it does nothing against a Kirov. One Flak Cannon can take out a Harrier, while two or three can take out a squadron. Keep your air defences grouped together to make them more effective.

Capture Tech Structures

These structures always start out neutral, so when you find these on the map, take them, guard them, and use them. Tech Hospitals, when captured, can be used to heal your infantry (troops); Tech Dericks are a source of income; Tech Outpost is a hospital for vehicles and can prove indispensable in your command.